

POLICY ON THE HANDLING AND STORAGE OF CHEMICALS

Rationale

The University of Mindanao recognizes the critical importance of safe chemical handling and storage in its academic, research, and operational activities. Improper management of chemicals may lead to hazardous exposures, fire risks, environmental contamination, and legal liabilities. This policy ensures that all chemical substances used within the university—particularly in laboratories, clinics, motorpools, and maintenance units—are properly handled, labeled, stored, and monitored in accordance with applicable national regulations and institutional safety standards. It also reflects the university's commitment to a safe learning and working environment, responsible chemical stewardship, and environmental sustainability in line with the Occupational Safety and Health Standards (OSHS), DENR DAO 92-29, and SDG 3 (Good Health and Well-being).

Scope

This policy applies to all faculty, researchers, laboratory technicians, staff, students, and third-party contractors who purchase, use, transport, handle, or store chemical substances on any University of Mindanao campus. It covers hazardous and non-hazardous chemicals, including reagents, solvents, acids, bases, compressed gases, cleaning agents, oils, fuels, and laboratory consumables.

Guiding Principles

1. **Chemical Classification and Inventory Management.** All chemicals must be appropriately identified, classified, and recorded before use or storage. Chemicals must be grouped according to compatibility (e.g., acids, bases, flammables, oxidizers, reactives) following the Globally Harmonized System of Classification and Labeling of Chemicals and included in a central inventory system maintained by each department. Laboratory custodians and unit heads must ensure that all chemicals' Safety Data Sheets (SDS) are accessible, updated, and made available to all users. A master chemical inventory must be submitted quarterly to the Pollution Control Officer (PCO) for compliance monitoring and DENR reporting.
2. **Proper Labeling and Signage.** All chemical containers, whether original or secondary, must be clearly labeled with the chemical name, concentration, hazard class (e.g., flammable, corrosive, toxic), date of receipt or preparation, and the responsible unit or laboratory. Labels must be resistant to moisture and chemical exposure. In addition, proper warning signage must be posted in storage areas, including hazard pictograms, emergency contact information, and the location of spill kits and safety showers.
3. **Storage Practices and Compatibility.** Chemicals must be stored in designated areas with adequate ventilation, spill containment, and segregation protocols. Flammable materials must be stored in flameproof cabinets, corrosives in acid-resistant cabinets, and oxidizers away from organic materials. Incompatible chemicals must never be stored together (e.g., acids and bases, flammables and oxidizers). Storage shelves must be equipped with secondary containment trays and anti-tipping restraints. All chemical

storage areas must be inaccessible to unauthorized personnel and inspected regularly for leaks, expired stock, and labeling deficiencies.

4. **Safe Handling and Personal Protective Equipment (PPE).** All personnel handling chemicals must undergo safety orientation and training on using personal protective equipment (PPE), including gloves, goggles, lab coats, and respirators, where applicable. Chemicals must only be handled in fume hoods or well-ventilated areas. Bulk chemical transfers must be done using appropriate pumps or transfer devices—never by pouring. Eating, drinking, and using mobile phones are strictly prohibited in chemical handling areas.
5. **Spill Prevention and Emergency Response.** Spill kits containing absorbents, neutralizers, and containment tools must be available in all chemical storage and usage areas. Personnel must be trained in minor spill cleanup procedures and emergency protocols. The incident must be reported immediately to the Pollution Control Officer, Safety Officer, and Disaster Risk Management–Environmental Management Committee (DRM-EMC) for major spills. Chemical spill response must follow the procedures outlined in the university's Contingency and Spill Response Plan.
6. **Waste Minimization and Disposal.** Chemicals must be purchased in quantities that match laboratory needs to avoid unnecessary storage. Expired or unused chemicals must be reported and submitted for disposal through the Hazardous Waste Accumulation Area, following the university's OPM 26.07 procedures. Under no circumstances may chemicals be disposed of through sinks, drains, or general waste bins without prior approval from the PCO.
7. **Procurement and Transport.** The laboratory or unit head and the PCO must review and approve all chemical procurement requests to ensure proper hazard assessment and storage capability. Chemicals must be transported in sealed secondary containers, with no open containers or unsealed packaging allowed. Compressed gas cylinders must be secured during transport and use.

Compliance

Compliance with this policy is mandatory. Non-compliance may result in disciplinary action, laboratory privileges suspension, or project approvals revocation. Periodic audits will be conducted by the Pollution Control Officer and Laboratory Management Office to ensure adherence to safety protocols and national regulations.

Implementation and Review

The implementation of this policy shall be led by the Pollution Control Office (PCO) and the Environment Management Committee (EMC) under the UMESH-GD Council. Regular audits shall be conducted to assess effectiveness and compliance. An annual sustainability report will be prepared to document progress, and a feedback mechanism will be established to solicit suggestions from the campus community. This policy shall be reviewed periodically by the PCO in coordination with the Physical Plant Maintenance and General Services (PPMGS), Quality Management Office (QMO), and other stakeholders in accordance with OPM 32.01. Revisions shall be officially communicated and immediately implemented upon approval.

Signed:

(Sgd) GUILLERMO P. TORRES, JR.
University President

Reference

OPM 26.06 – Waste Management and Segregation; February 28, 2025; Rev. 2
OPM 26.07 – Disposal of Hazardous Waste; Effective October 01, 2024; Rev. 0
DAO 92-29 – Hazardous Waste Management
RA 6969 – Toxic Substances and Hazardous and Nuclear Wastes Control Act
DENR-EMB Regulations
DOLE Department Order 198 – OSH Law Implementing Rules
Globally Harmonized System of Classification and Labeling of Chemicals